

A STRAW HUT MEDIA LIMITED SERIES



BORN EXPLORERS

WORKING TITLE

A journey through the cities that taught the world to travel — one harbor, one market, one plate at a time.

8 × 45–60 MIN

PREMIUM TRAVEL SERIES

ONE CITY PER EPISODE



THE SERIES

The biggest industry on Earth has never had its origin story told.

Born Explorers is a travel show — markets, kitchens, harbors, streets — through the eight cities that taught the world to travel. The history hides in plain sight:

saffron on a Seville plate, empire in a London teacup, the buffet behind Cancún’s resort wall.

Spices, wars, and empires moved along the same routes tourists follow today — and tourism grew bigger than oil or automobiles without anyone ever telling its story. The question driving the series: *we were born explorers. How did we become tourists, and what do we become next?*

1.4B INTERNATIONAL TRIPS TAKEN EVERY YEAR	1 in 10 JOBS ON EARTH SUPPORTED BY TRAVEL & TOURISM	~10% OF GLOBAL GDP — ROUGHLY \$11 TRILLION
185 YEARS SINCE THOMAS COOK INVENTED THE PACKAGE TOUR		

WHY NOW

Travel is the story of this decade.

- Overtourism revolts in Venice and Barcelona
- Post-pandemic “revenge travel” breaking every record
- AI rewriting how trips are planned and sold
- Climate and conflict redrawing the map in real time

True crime, food, and music have all had the prestige-history treatment. Travel — the biggest subject of them all — never has. This is that series.

Eight cities, five hundred years.

Each episode is one city — a chapter of the timeline, in order, and a living destination today. The history and the present tense are always in the same frame.



Seville

1519 · THE AGE OF EXPLORATION

Tapas under orange trees, in the port that licensed every ship to the New World — Columbus is buried in the cathedral, and Magellan sailed from these docks to prove the world has no edge. The exchange went both ways: tomatoes, chili, and chocolate entered Europe here, and no cuisine on Earth was ever the same.

Interviews: Sevillano chefs and market vendors; historians of exploration; the Archivo de Indias.



Venice

1700S · THE GRAND TOUR

Cicchetti and spritz on canals the spice trade built — pepper and cinnamon made Venice rich centuries before beauty did. Then Europe's young aristocracy arrives on the Grand Tour, and the tourist is born.

Interviews: bacaro owners and gondolier families; Grand Tour historians.



London

1841 · THE PACKAGE TOUR

Afternoon tea — the most British ritual there is — is China and India in a cup, empire served on porcelain. From here, Thomas Cook charts a train in 1841 and accidentally invents mass tourism.

Interviews: tea masters and hoteliers; Cook biographers; historians of empire.

IV

Paris

1900 – 1950 · GLAMOUR AND STEEL

Dinner at the Ritz, a berth on the Orient Express — Paris invents travel as glamour, and the world's fairs sell the planet as spectacle. Then two world wars stop it cold, and paid vacation hands leisure to everyone.

Interviews: the grand hotel dynasties; chefs of the palace kitchens; golden-age historians.

V

Honolulu

1959 – 1980 · THE JET AGE

Poke, plate lunch, and mai tais — a menu written by plantation workers from Japan, China, Portugal, and the Philippines. Then statehood and the 747 turn the kingdom they built into everyone's paradise, in a single generation.

Interviews: Native Hawaiian voices; the cooks behind the plate lunch; the surviving pioneers of the jet-age boom.

VI

Cancún

1974 – 2005 · PARADISE, INC.

At the swim-up bar the buffet never ends; beyond the resort wall, cochinita pibil is still cooked in the ground, the way it was before a government computer picked this sandbar in 1974. Mass tourism becomes an industrial product — and the money leaves paradise as fast as the tourists arrive.

Interviews: Yucatecan cooks and hotel workers; the planners who built it; cruise and hotel CEOs.

VII

Barcelona

2008 – TODAY · THE ALGORITHM

La Boqueria is so jammed with day-trippers that locals can't buy dinner in their own market. Budget airlines, Airbnb, and Instagram flood the city until "tourists go home" is painted on the walls — the first great revolt against the industry travel built.

Interviews: market vendors and residents; the disruptor founders; city hall.

You can eat the whole world in one evening here — a paradise built entirely on purpose, and the most-visited place in America. Tourism's final form is being prototyped in Orlando, and the people building the next era make their case.

Interviews: the designers of manufactured paradise; the CEOs betting on the future.

Tightens to six by folding Venice into Seville and Barcelona into Orlando.

THE VOICES

Three kinds of witness in every episode.

The Locals

EVERY EPISODE EATS FIRST

Chefs, market vendors, hoteliers, and families — the city as the people who feed it live it.

The Historians

THE STORY UNDER THE STREETS

Historians of exploration, empire, the spice routes, and leisure — surfacing the past inside the present.

The Titans

WHO RUNS TRAVEL NOW

The founders and CEOs of the biggest travel brands — doors opened by G Adventures founder Bruce Poon Tip (*The Last Tourist*, Order of Canada), one of the slate's marquee voices — plus the surviving pioneers of the first boom.

THE FEEL

A trip, not a lecture.

Open on the senses

Every episode starts in the present tense — a market at dawn, a kitchen mid-service, a harbor at golden hour. The history arrives through the food, not a chalkboard.

History you can taste

Follow the ingredients — saffron, pepper, tea, sugar, chili — and they trace the spice routes, wars, and colonizations that carried them.

Archive as spectacle

A century of postcards, steamship brochures, and Pan Am promos — never before mined for series TV.

COMPARABLES

The appetite is proven.

The Last Tourist

FEATURE DOC · 2022

Bruce's proof of concept — this series at ten times the scale.

Salt Fat Acid Heat

NETFLIX

The structural blueprint: one idea, one place per episode, told through ingredients.

Parts Unknown

CNN

The gold standard: a travel show that smuggled in history and politics.

Stanley Tucci: Searching for Italy

CNN / NAT GEO

Culture through food and place — awards, ratings, and a bidding war.

Somebody Feed Phil

NETFLIX

Joyful food-travel at mainstream scale.

THE STUDIO

Straw Hut Media

The LA studio behind the official *Only Murders in the Building* podcast with Disney/Hulu — now in its sixth season — plus a slate of celebrity-led and studio-partner shows.

Born Explorers arrives as a package: interview access already in hand — including Bruce Poon Tip and his CEO peer group — with a companion podcast and social engine built in.

ON THE TITLE

Born Explorers names the thesis. Also in the room:

The Invention of Travel

Wish You Were Here

Paradise, Inc.

The Tourist Age

THE ASK

A development conversation.

A premium travel limited series — built as eight cities, tightens to six. The on-camera host is open: a casting opportunity for the platform. Sizzle, full treatment, and interview commitments available on request.

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